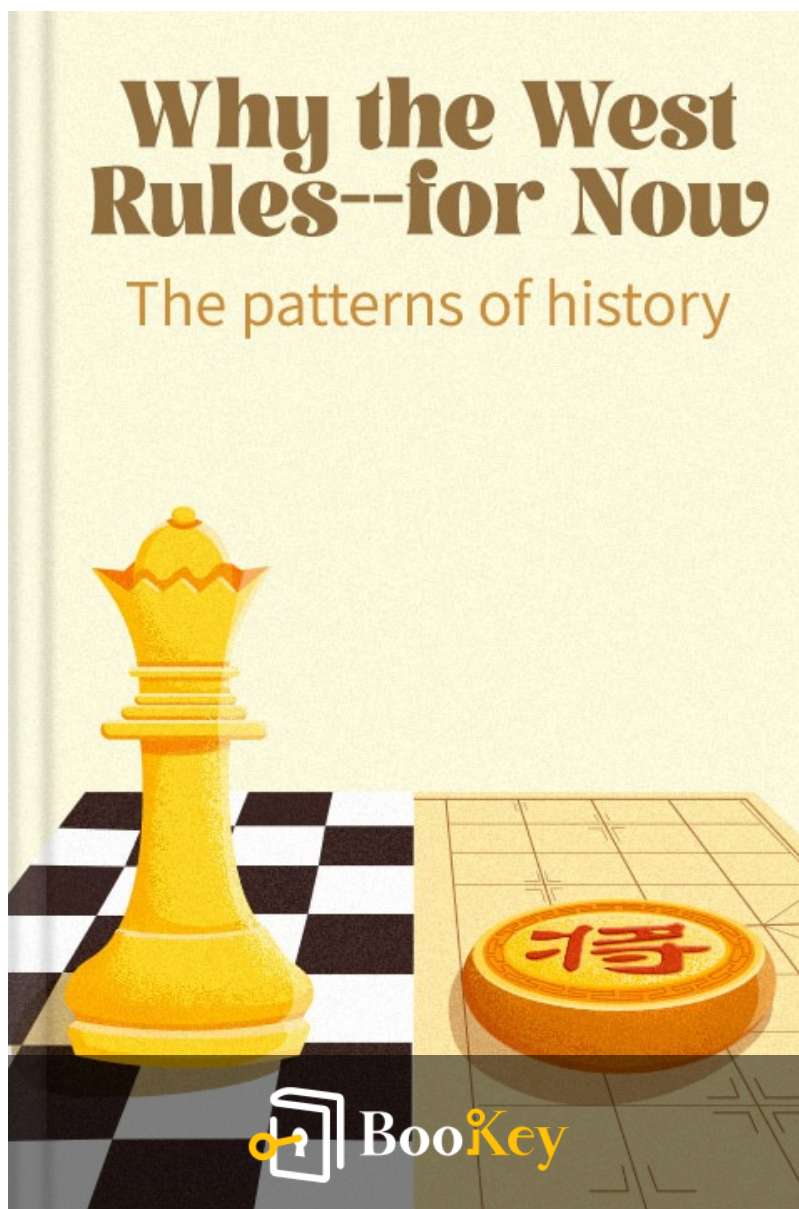


# Why the West Rules—for Now PDF

Ian Morris



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# Why the West Rules—for Now

The patterns of history

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## About the book

Winston Churchill once said: “The farther backward you can look, the farther forward you are likely to see.” Using history as a mirror, we can learn why empires and civilizations rise and fall. Unlike most scholars that only focus on the past two or three centuries of modern times, the author of this book goes back to the starting point of Eastern and Western civilization and creates an index to measure their respective levels of development over time. He provides us with a comprehensive history of the fierce race toward development between East and the West.

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## About the author

Ian Morris is a world-renowned historian and Professor of Classics at Stanford University. He has published eleven books and more than eighty essays. This book is Morris' magnum opus. It has been on Amazon's bestseller list since its publication, and was nominated for the Orwell Prize in 2011.

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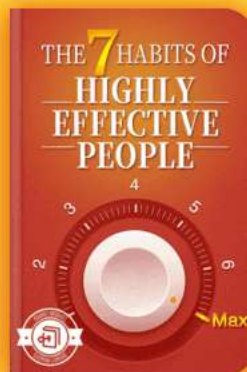


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# Chapter 1 : Overview

Hi, welcome to Bookey. Today we will unlock the book *Why the West Rules--for Now: The Patterns of History, and What They Reveal About the Future*.

As many people know, China was once the most advanced and prosperous country in the world. It was the Second Great Exchange that brought much of the East's technology and culture to the West. Today, more than a thousand years later, Western civilization led by the United States has become the world's leading power. Why did the once-prosperous East fall behind, and why did the West rise? Will the East surpass the West again in the future?

The author of this book, Ian Morris, answers these questions one by one. He believes that in order to truly understand history, one needs to study it with a holistic perspective. This perspective looks far beyond the last few centuries, and spans thousands of years from the origin of Eastern and Western civilization to the present. One needs to view the long history of mankind as a fully interconnected story. Only in this way can we explain historical developments and predict the future more objectively without drawing one-sided conclusions.



In order to better compare the historical levels of development of Eastern and Western civilization, Morris utilizes a mathematical metric. He produces an index that scores the development levels of the East and the West at various historical stages. In this way, our ambiguous and qualitative perceptions of social development can be compared in a more straightforward and quantitative manner.

Morris believes that the purpose of studying history is to project the future. Following his historical analysis, Morris makes scientific predictions of future trends based on his observations. His views are thought provoking and he makes several constructive proposals. We'll divide his book into three main sections:

Part One: How can we measure the levels of development of Eastern and Western societies?

Part Two: How did the West and the East Develop?

Part Three: How long can the West continue to dominate?





## Chapter 2 : How can we measure the levels of development of Eastern and Western societies?

In part one, we'll address three questions regarding development—namely, what to measure, when to measure and where to measure.

Social development is a complex concept that encompasses economics, culture, politics, education, and more. Measuring social development is indeed a very challenging task. But as Albert Einstein once said, science can be tested in the simplest way. In order to measure social development, Morris selects a few simple yet effective criteria: energy capture, urbanism, information processing, and the capacity to launch war. Urbanism mainly measures a society's ability to organize its economic activities, without which, even if a society possesses abundant resources, it won't be able to utilize them efficiently.

Morris takes New York City—the most developed city in the world in the year 2000—as a reference point, and set its social development index at 1,000 points. Out of this 1,000



points, energy capture, urbanism, information processing, and the capacity to launch war each accounted for 250 points. Using this benchmark, Morris is able to score and compare the various stages of development of Eastern and Western civilization throughout history.

If New York City in the year 2000 is the benchmark, which year should be the starting point of this measurement? While many scholars mainly focus on the past 2- 3 hundred—at most 5 hundred years— of recent history, Morris sets the starting point of his measurement at far more distant period—the origin of human civilization around 14,000 BC, the end of the last Ice Age. At that time, the world began warming up. This created an ecological environment that was more suitable for our ancestors to survive and reproduce, and civilization began to take shape. Taking 14,000 BC as the starting point and 2000 AD as the end, Morris samples different time periods of human history and measured their levels of social development.

After deciding the time frame, we now come to the issue of where to measure., Morris chooses the most developed area during a particular time period —politically, economically, and culturally—in the East and West, respectively, as the



sample. There is an important concept that needs to be clarified here: which regions are we referring to when we talk about the East and the West? Intuitively, many might think of the West as Europe and the United States, and the East as China.

To define the geographical scope of the East and West, Morris takes us back to 14,000 BC at the end of the Ice Age. Here we're in the Hilly Flanks of western Eurasia, early humans leaving their hunter-gatherer lifestyle for the first time and begin to domesticate animals and plants, build simple shelters, and settle down to live in larger groups. This region may be seen as the nucleus of Western civilization. In the bookey of *Guns, Germs, and Steel*, we've talked about the geographical advantage of this place. You can look for that bookey to learn more.

The Hilly Flanks area lies in an arc-shaped belt formed by the Tigris, Euphrates and Jordan valleys. Human civilization was born here and expanded outward to Mesopotamia, the Nile Valley, and, gradually, the Mediterranean coast and Europe. Therefore, Morris refers to the societies that originated out of the Hilly Flanks area as the West. These include the Mediterranean Basin, Europe, and, in recent



centuries, the Americas, Australia, New Zealand, and Siberia. The East refers to the societies that evolved at the easternmost tip of Eurasia. They originated from the ancient Chinese civilization in the Yellow River Basin and expanded outward—with China as the center—to vast areas including Japan in the north and, the Indochina Peninsula in the south.

Looking at history in its entirety, you will find that from 11000 BC to 1400 AD, the most developed area of the West had mostly been on the east coast of the Mediterranean, the triangle formed by Iraq, Egypt, and Greece today. It might be surprising to many: These seemingly chaotic and barren regions have had such a long and glorious history. From 1400 AD onwards, the center of Western civilization continued to move northwest, first to northern Italy, then to Spain and France, and then to the United Kingdom, Belgium, the Netherlands, and Germany. The center crossed the Atlantic Ocean in the 1900s and has remained in North America up to the present. The center of the East, on the other hand, remained in the Yellow and Yangtze River regions until 1850. It expanded to Japan in the 1900s and returned to southeastern China in the 2000s.

Now that we have introduced Morris' rules for measuring



social development in some detail, let's summarize: Morris uses energy capture, urbanism, information processing, and the capacity to launch wars as the four parameters to measure social development. He looked at history from 14000 BC to 2000 AD, and conducted comprehensive comparative research on the core areas of Eastern and Western societies.

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## Chapter 3 : How did the West and the East Develop?

Now that we've explained the method of measurement, let's compare the level of social development in the East and the West over the past 16,000 years. We'll divide this historical period into four parts.

Let's start with the period from 14000 BC to 1000 BC, when early agriculture first emerged and nations were formed.

In 11000 BC, people living in the Hilly Flanks areas had already begun to plant rye in order to harvest larger crops. In 10800 BC, the earth was getting warmer and glaciers were melting, then the world entered the Ice Age and everything changed dramatically. In 9600 BC, when the Ice Age ended, people in the Hilly Flanks areas began to grow rye again—this time even more actively than before. By 7500 BC, cultivated plants were everywhere. In the East, agricultural development first appeared in China. Between 8000 BC and 7500 BC, people in the Yangtze River Basin began to plant rice. In 6500 BC, people in the Yellow River Valley began to plant millet. Rice became fully cultivated





around 4500 BC, and millet around 5500 BC. At this point, in terms of having a stable food source, the West was one step ahead of the East.

The West was also one step ahead when it came to information processing. Primitive writing first appeared in the West by 9000 BC. In the East, by comparison, primitive writing didn't appear until after 7000 BC. Over the next 5000 years, those simple signs gradually developed into pictograms, which were adopted by the emperor of the Shang Dynasty as the earliest formal writing system in the East.

Around 3300 BC, the earliest city in the West, Uruk, was founded on the Mesopotamian plains. It would develop into a state with a central government and bureaucracy. In 3100 BC, the largest kingdom at the time- with more than one million residents- appeared in the Nile River Basin: Ancient Egypt. On the other hand, the earliest cities and states in the

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## Chapter 4 : How long can the West continue to dominate?

Now we have walked you through the long history of the East and West. But there are still a few more questions to be answered: Why does the West still dominate the world? How long will that continue? How will the world develop in the future?

Let's start with the first question. Why does the West rule the world in the present?

In order to survive, humans evolved to obtain energy from their environment in a different way than animals. This has led to the development of civilization. However, in the process of development, human societies inflicted upon themselves the paradox of social development we mentioned earlier. Social development creates factors that magnify the pain of the inevitable downturns. As a result, society might develop rapidly for one period, but stagnate or even regress in the following period. This applies to both the East and the West.



So, why the West? Morris thinks the reason lies in geography. Morris believes that while geography may affect the process of social development, social development, in turn, also changes the meaning of geography and the natural environment.

For example, global warming made the Hilly Flanks area a promised land, where humans first started agriculture. However, when society developed to a certain level, the Mesopotamia region—once impossible to cultivate due to the flooding of rivers—made greater progress in agricultural development, because people learned to build canals, store water, and use the water from flooding rivers for irrigation. This once backward area showed a late-mover advantage and took the lead in establishing cities and larger states.

Similarly, 5,000 years ago, Portugal, Spain, France, and the United Kingdom were on the western side of the European continent close to the Atlantic Ocean, far away from the civilizations of Mesopotamia and Egypt. This was a major geographical disadvantage at the time and curbed the development of the region. However, in the 16th century, after the Europeans invented a new type of ship that could cross the previously impassable Atlantic Ocean, the situation



began to reverse. The previous geographical disadvantages turned into a huge advantage, and Western Europe has since taken the lead in the Atlantic economy.

This is how the West, because of its geographical advantages, was able to take the lead during the Industrial Revolution and now dominate the world. But how long can this domination last? Morris predicts that by 2103, the East will once again surpass the West.

In 1900, the emerging subcontinent empire of the United States was challenging the maritime empires of Western Europe. The war accelerated this trend. After the First and Second World Wars in 1914 and 1939, the United States rose to become the new world hegemon. Since then, the Western core has shifted from Europe to the United States. Since the founding of the People's Republic of China in 1949 and the reforms and opening up in 1978, China has entered the fast lane of social development. In the 1970s, the productivity of the United States was 20 times that of China. The U.S. produced 22% of the world's total commodities, while China only accounted for 5%. By 2000, the productivity of the United States was only 7 times that of China. The U.S.' share of global commodities remained roughly unchanged, while





China's share had risen from 5% to 14%.

In the 19th century, the world's factory was Britain, and in the 20th century, it shifted to the United States. Now China has become the world's factory. The social development score of the West and the East was 2.4 to 1 in 1900, and it became 1.6 to 1 in 2000. According to the development speed of the East and the West in the 20th century, Morris predicts that the East will once again surpass the West by 2103. At that time, the social development index will exceed 5000 points. What will the world look like at that time?

According to Morris, we might see mega metropolises with 140 million people, which is equivalent to the combined populations of Tokyo, Mexico City, New York, São Paulo, Mumbai, Delhi, and Shanghai. Per capita energy consumption will reach 1.3 million kcal, and science fiction may become reality, as genetic engineering and bionics transform the human condition. But as the paradox of social development suggests, development and crisis always go hand in hand. And this time, the crisis is likely to bring the world to an end.

The first crisis is climate change. In 2006, the Stern Review





released by the United Kingdom estimated that, if we do not pay attention to environmental protection, by 2100, climate change will cut global economic output by 20% down from today's level. If climate change is not contained, the polar ice sheet will melt by 2100. Sea levels will rise, farmland will be flooded, food production will decline, and a widespread famine will follow. The first to be affected will be Africa and those Asian countries in tropical and subtropical regions. Most of the world's poorest live in these regions. There will be 200 million immigrants entering Europe and the United States to seek refuge. History has shown that large-scale immigration will bring plagues, such as H1N1 flu, the Black Death, and AIDS. These disasters will lead to the complete collapse of some unstable government regimes, such as Afghanistan and Somalia, leaving those countries in chaos and terrorism. We might fall into the worst situation, and will very likely head toward complete destruction.

Therefore, we must take a long-term view of these potential threats. The world is developing rapidly and globalization has brought countries closer than ever before. In the face of nuclear war, climate change, terrorism, disease, financial crises, food and water shortages and other global issues, no country can survive alone. History tells us that whether we



are from the East or the West, human beings are ultimately the same. We've taken a long time to understand each other, but the division of East and West must be resigned to the past. We must merge with each other and face the new challenges together.

This is the end of Part Three. Morris believes that the West started the Industrial Revolution and dominated the world because of its geographical advantages. But by 2103, when its social development index is expected to exceed 5000 points, the East will once again surpass the West. At that time, however, society may be facing many different crises. Climate change will lead to large-scale immigration, and plagues might appear in some regions, some unstable regimes might fall apart, and terrorism will prevail. The East and the West will need to work with each other and meet the new challenges together.



## Chapter 5 : Summary & Review

We have now come near to the end of today's bookey of Why the West Rules - For now.

Looking at Morris' social development chart, we find that the development curves of the East and the West have converged twice in history: The first time in 541 AD during China's Northern and Southern Dynasties, and the second time in 1773 AD, during China's Qing Dynasty. The West took the lead before 541 AD, and the East took over from 541 to 1773. Since 1773, the West has been leading again. However, looking at the development curve at the end of the 20th century, the development speed of the East is significantly higher than that of the West. Morris predicts that the next convergence point will come in 2103, when the East catches up with the West again.

Through this chart, we learned the development paths of Eastern and Western societies, as well as their different characteristics at each stage. Morris explains the driving forces behind the differences in social development. He also explains how the paradox of social development has led to an invisible ceiling. All of human history has proceeded back



and forth, up and down under the guidance of this "invisible hand".

Morris believes the next 40 years are very important. In the race of development and destruction, mankind must put aside our hostility, work together, and buy more time to start an energy revolution, slow down climate change, and avoid an all-round nuclear war. To prevent the world from destruction, we need to race against time and make the necessary changes before it is too late.

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